claimed they had found a convenient excuse to ‘play the martyr card’.[56] The Meghalaya fracas demonstrated how easily differences over food habits could derail the BJP’s political project in the region. Like Biren Singh did in Manipur, clarifications were also issued by the party in Nagaland, Meghalaya, Arunachal Pradesh and Mizoram. In each state, local party leaders insisted that the BJP’s central leadership was well aware of the need for flexibility. ‘Ban on cow slaughter like the one in UP won’t take effect in Nagaland if our party comes to power,’ explained Nagaland BJP Chief Visasolie Lhoungu to a newspaper. ‘The reality here is very different and our central leaders are aware of that.’[57] Similarly, in Aizawl, the Mizoram BJP chief announced that ‘with the consent of Amit Shahji, national president of BJP, we are not supporting the ban’. In Itanagar, Tapir Gao, the state BJP chief, added, ‘In the northeastern state, we are taking all kinds of meat except human … The individual food habits are not the BJP’s concern. It is the Opposition that is politicising the issue.’[58]

The discomfiture over beef is indicative of the cultural tensions inherent in the BJP’s Northeast expansion. Cow slaughter is not banned in Arunachal Pradesh, Mizoram, Meghalaya, Nagaland, Tripura and Sikkim. In Manipur, it was decreed as an offence by the maharaja in 1939 but is still heavily consumed. In Assam, only ‘cattle fit for slaughter’ may be killed.[59] Government data shows that beef is the highest consumed meat in Meghalaya. In Nagaland, it is a close second to pork. In Manipur, it is the second most consumed meat after fish and prawns. In the Northeast overall, it is the fifth most consumed meat after fish/prawns, chicken, pork and mutton.[60] At a Manipur election rally in 2017, for example, one of the BJP’s allies, the Naga People’s Front, followed up political speeches with a feast for the assembled crowd, serving up pork stew and chunky beef curry.

As the journalist Smita Gupta has pointed out, the BJP has put ‘the issue of beef, which is part of the diet for a large section of the people here, on the back-burner, even as it runs a virulent and vigorous campaign against its consumption elsewhere in the country’.[61] Rajat Sethi and Shubrastha, both of whom have worked